

Early Alert Protocol

Odisee Brussels · Student Success Project 2025–2026

Tool 2 of 3 · Part of the Bridging the Gap Project

A complete guidance document for teaching staff, programme coordinators, and peer mentors at Odisee Brussels — bringing together the five-step protocol, traffic light framework, roles and responsibilities, email-free outreach alternatives, evidence base, international examples, SWOT analysis, and SMART criteria in one ready-to-use resource.

5 Steps Signal · Record · Reach Out · Connect · Follow Up <i>Built into Toledo · 0€ extra cost</i>	55% of high-risk students improved <i>after just one warm message</i> <i>(Jayaprakash et al., 2014)</i>	3,000+ students identified per year <i>Kingston University SEAtS · zero extra</i> <i>staff workload</i>
--	---	---

1. What Is the Early Alert Protocol?

The Early Alert Protocol is a structured, proactive system that enables teaching staff and programme coordinators at Odisee Brussels to identify students who are beginning to show signs of academic risk — and to reach out to them with support before problems become unrecoverable.

It is not surveillance. It is not a formal disciplinary process. It is a coordinated chain of care — built into the normal rhythms of teaching, mentoring and coordination — that ensures no student quietly disappears without anyone noticing.

Students at Odisee Brussels do not decide to quit. They drift — quietly, one missed session at a time — until one day they are gone. By the time traditional grading reveals the problem, the student's connection to the institution is often already too weak to repair. The protocol interrupts that drift at the earliest possible moment, when intervention is still easy, inexpensive, and effective.

The most powerful thing an institution can do when a student begins to drift is notice — and say so. Warmly. Directly. Early.

2. The Five-Step Protocol

Five steps. Each with a defined action, owner, and timeline. No step requires a new system. No step requires email from a professor. The professor clicks one colour in Toledo. Everything after that is handled by the peer mentor and coordinator.

#	Step	What Happens	Who Does It
1	Signal Detected	A warning sign is observed — missed sessions, sudden silence, late submissions, visible distress. Any staff	Lecturer, Peer Mentor, or Coordinator

#	Step	What Happens	Who Does It
		member or mentor can spot a signal using the traffic light framework (Green · Amber · Red). The professor clicks one colour in Toledo. That is their only action.	
2	Record — Concern Note	The observer records what they saw in a brief Concern Note. Not a disciplinary document. A factual observation — five minutes to complete — that builds a picture if patterns emerge.	Person who observed the signal
3	Reach Out	The first outreach always feels like care, not control. A warm, direct message from the peer mentor — someone the student already knows and trusts. Even one message is enough to change outcomes for many students (Jayaprakash et al., 2014). If the peer mentor notices a student struggling in their bi-weekly session, they can also flag it directly — without waiting for a Toledo signal.	Peer Mentor (primary) · Coordinator for Red alerts
4	Connect to Support	The coordinator matches the type of concern to the right support service — counselling, financial guidance, language support, or crisis response.	Programme Coordinator
5	Follow Up — 14-Day Rule	After any Amber or Red alert, the person who initiated checks in again within 14 days. Logged in the same Concern Note. No student falls through because someone forgot.	Person who initiated outreach

3. The Traffic Light System

Not every signal is an emergency. The traffic light framework helps staff and mentors calibrate their response — ensuring proportionate, timely action without overreaction.

Level	Warning Signs	Action Required
GREEN	Slightly reduced engagement. Quieter than usual. One missed session.	Watch and note. No immediate outreach needed. Monitor at next session.
AMBER	Two or more missed sessions. Late submissions. Visible stress or withdrawal. Mentor flags concern.	Reach out this week. Warm, direct message from peer mentor. Complete Concern Note. Escalate to coordinator if no response in 3 days.
RED	Complete disappearance. Expressed crisis. Financial emergency. Mental health concern. Risk of immediate dropout.	Act today. Coordinator informed within 24 hours. Direct referral to student support service. Mentor does not manage this alone.

4. Roles and Responsibilities

Every person in the system has a defined role. Nobody carries too much. Nobody is left unsure of what to do next.

Role	Responsibility	What They Do NOT Do
Teaching Staff	Observe students during sessions. Click traffic light in Toledo for Amber or Red signals. Complete Concern Note in five minutes. That is their only required action.	Send individual emails. Manage follow-up. Make referrals. Handle personal disclosures directly.
Peer Mentor	Complete five-weekly check-in notes. Flag any student showing withdrawal, stress or difficulty to head mentor immediately. Handle all first-contact outreach after a signal is raised.	Manage Red-level concerns alone. Make formal referrals. Replace professional counselling.
Head Mentor	Collect five-weekly mentor notes. Escalate Amber or Red concerns to the coordinator within 48 hours.	Make final decisions on referrals. Contact student support services directly.
Programme Coordinator	Receive all concern notes. Ensure every Amber and Red alert has a 14-day follow-up. Connect students to the right support. Lead mid-year and end-of-year reviews.	Manage every alert personally. Replace student support services.
Student Support Service	Receive referrals from coordinators. Provide counselling, financial guidance, language support, or crisis response. Feed outcomes back to coordinator.	Proactively identify students. First point of contact for all concerns.

5. No Email — Four Outreach Alternatives

Partner meeting and professor feedback confirmed: individual emails from teaching staff to struggling students do not work at Odisee Brussels. Students rarely respond. Staff carry extra burden. Here are four alternatives — all zero extra burden on teaching staff.

Channel	How It Works	Why It Works Better Than Email
Peer Mentor Direct Message	The peer mentor reaches out through a personal message via Teams, WhatsApp, or in-person at the next session. Warm and casual — not official.	Students respond to peers. A message from someone they already know carries none of the anxiety that a lecturer message does.
Toledo Traffic Light Signal	A coloured engagement indicator on the student's Toledo course page — green, amber, or red — visible when the student logs in. Students who see amber often self-correct without any outreach needed.	Purdue University proved this: many students self-correct the moment they see their own signal. No staff action required until the student does not self-correct.

Channel	How It Works	Why It Works Better Than Email
Automated SMS or Teams Message	When a student misses two consecutive sessions, an automated warm text is sent from the system. No staff member writes it. It goes immediately.	Kingston University identifies 3,000+ students per year this way. Zero staff time. The message reaches students in the moment it is most needed.
WhatsApp Chatbot	A chatbot available 24/7 in Dutch, French, and English. Students ask about struggling or feeling overwhelmed. The bot responds warmly and flags the coordinator if the student signals real distress.	University of the Free State doubled student reach using a WhatsApp bot while cutting live support requests by 83%. Migrant-background students who would never walk into a support office will text at midnight.

6. Evidence Base — 20 Sources Across Six Themes

The protocol is grounded in 20 peer-reviewed sources across six themes. Each theme directly shapes a specific element of the protocol design.

Theme 1 — Why Students Leave and When

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to Odisee Brussels
Bean (1980)	Dropout is an institutional problem, not a personal one. Students leave when they feel disconnected — gradually and invisibly.	The signal to watch for at Odisee is not grades — it is disconnection. This is what the traffic light catches.
Seidman (2005)	Early Identification + Early Intensive Intervention = Retention. Every week of delay makes intervention harder.	Active monitoring begins in Week 1, not Week 6. Seidman's formula justifies this from the first page.
Yorke (1999)	Most departure decisions are made within the first six weeks — before any formal assessment.	The critical window opens on Day 1. Active monitoring must begin at induction, not mid-term.
Naylor & Mifsud (2019)	Dropout is produced by structural inequalities — passive services do not reach those who need them.	The protocol is active by design. It goes to the student. The student does not have to find it.
Pascarella & Terenzini (2005)	Two things predict persistence: academic integration and social integration. Both must be present.	The protocol addresses both: academic signals through Toledo data and social signals through mentor check-ins.

Theme 2 — Proactive Outreach

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to Odisee Brussels
Scrivener et al. (2015)	CUNY ASAP assigned every disadvantaged student a proactive advisor. Graduation rates doubled in three years.	The peer mentor is Odisee's version of the ASAP advisor — reaching the student at every bi-weekly session, without requiring self-referral.

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to Odisee Brussels
Bettinger & Baker (2014)	Students who received proactive coaching had significantly higher persistence and GPA than those simply offered coaching.	The direction of first contact is decisive. The protocol always moves FROM the institution TO the student.
Karp & Bork (2012)	Students said: I did not know I could ask for help or I thought asking meant I was not smart enough.	The protocol removes the requirement to know the rules before accessing help. It reaches students who would never self-refer.
Jayaprakash et al. (2014)	55% of high-risk students improved after one warm outreach message. 25% moved from high-risk to no risk.	Even one warm message changes behaviour. This principle is embedded in every step of the protocol.

Theme 3 — Belonging

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to Odisee Brussels
Walton & Cohen (2011)	A single brief belonging message improved GPA and persistence over three years for minority students.	Even one warm message in Step 3 has documented three-year effects. The simplest action can have the longest reach.
Strayhorn (2012)	Belonging is universal but barriers are not equally distributed. First-generation students interpret uncertainty as evidence they should not be there.	For Brussels students, the protocol is a belonging intervention. Belonging determines whether they stay.
Thomas (2012)	The single most effective belonging action is a staff member personally acknowledging a student in the first weeks.	The protocol formalises this noticing. It ensures it happens reliably, for every at-risk student, every time.

Theme 4 — Technology and LMS-Based Alerts

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to Odisee Brussels
Arnold & Pistilli (2012) — Purdue	Traffic light placed inside the LMS. Students saw their own signal on login. 55% of high-risk improved; 25% moved to no risk.	Toledo already exists. The traffic light lives inside it. One coordinator click. Zero staff email required.
Barber & Sharkey (2012)	Students who could see their own engagement risk in a dashboard self-corrected before any lecturer had to act.	Many students become their own first responders. Only those who do not self-correct are flagged to staff.
Wise (2014)	Tools embedded in existing platforms were used consistently. Standalone systems were abandoned.	Build inside Toledo, not alongside it. The best alert system requires no behaviour change from staff or students.

Theme 5 — First-Generation and Migrant Students

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to Odisee Brussels
Stephens et al. (2012)	First-generation students lack the invisible map of how university works — not capability, but cultural knowledge.	Brussels students are not less capable. They are navigating a system not designed for them. The protocol redesigns the system's behaviour.
Crozier & Reay (2011)	Working-class students spend energy learning to be a university student while others spend it on academic work.	The protocol acknowledges this hidden disadvantage and provides active support rather than assuming students know how to ask.
Barsegyan & Maas (2024)	First-generation immigrant students face double disadvantage: no parental HE knowledge AND no cultural capital from host society.	The most contextually precise source for Odisee Brussels. Active protocols reach this group. Standard services do not.

Theme 6 — Implementation and Success Factors

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to Odisee Brussels
Kuh et al. (2005)	The most effective retention universities embedded support in daily life, made it proactive, and used multiple touchpoints over time.	The three-tool system mirrors exactly this structure. Peer mentoring · Early Alert · SRL — daily, proactive, and multi-point.
Tinto (1993)	Dropout is the slow erosion of connection to studies, institution and people. Interventions that restore all three work best.	The five-step protocol restores all three connections simultaneously — academic (coordinator), institutional (referral), and personal (mentor).

7. Real-World Universities — 8 International Examples

Early alert has been implemented and rigorously evaluated at universities across the world. The examples below demonstrate what this protocol produces in practice.

University / Country	What They Did and Results	What Odisee Can Take
Georgia State University USA · 55,000 students · Since 2012	Tracks 800 risk factors per student daily — LMS logins, missed assignments, grade dips, financial status. When triggered, an alert goes to an advisor automatically within 48 hours. No professor involved. Results: +5% freshman retention · 400,000 one-on-one interventions · achievement gap eliminated for first-generation and minority students.	Connect Toledo data (login frequency, submission timestamps, scores) to a simple dashboard that auto-flags students to the coordinator — not the professor. No new system needed if Toledo already logs this data.

University / Country	What They Did and Results	What Odisee Can Take
Purdue University — Course Signals USA · 220+ students per cohort	Traffic light placed inside each student's course page in the LMS. Students saw green/amber/red when they logged in. Many self-corrected immediately. Results: 55% of high-risk improved · 25% moved from high-risk to no risk.	Add a coloured engagement indicator to every Toledo course page. Students see it when they log in. Peer mentor follows up with any student showing amber for two consecutive weeks.
Kingston University — SEAtS London UK · 3,000+ students per year	Unified system connecting attendance scanning, LMS activity, and assignment submissions. When a student drops below 20% attendance, the system sends an automatic warm text. No staff member writes it. Results: 3,000+ students identified per year · improved widening participation outcomes.	Set up an automated SMS or Teams message triggered when a student misses two consecutive sessions. Warm, short, links to the peer mentor. Zero staff time.
University of the Free State — KvsieChat South Africa · WhatsApp chatbot	AI chatbot on WhatsApp available 24/7 in multiple languages. Students ask about struggling, feeling anxious, missing class. The chatbot flags it and routes to a human advisor. Results: 83% fewer live support requests · 2x student reach after AI upgrade.	A WhatsApp chatbot for Odisee Brussels in Dutch, French, and English — available 24/7. Perfect for migrant-background students who feel less comfortable approaching staff in person.
Marist College — OAAI New York USA	Tested early alert across large research universities, small colleges, and two-year institutions. Critical finding: harsh or formal outreach caused some students to withdraw. Warm language consistently produced the best outcomes. Results: Proven across all institution types.	Warm language is built into every step of the Odisee protocol. The concern note, outreach message, and follow-up are all framed as care — not surveillance.
Dutch University Field Experiment Netherlands · Plak et al. (2021)	Rigorous field experiment showing early warning systems made student counselling significantly more effective by enabling proactive outreach. The effect was strongest for students who would not seek help on their own. Published: Higher Education Quarterly.	Directly mirrors the Odisee Brussels profile. The students who benefit most from proactive outreach are exactly those who would never self-refer — first-generation, migrant-background, language-barrier students.
CUNY ASAP — Scrivener et al. (2015) New York USA	Every disadvantaged student was assigned a proactive advisor who reached out to them — not the other way around. Results: Graduation rates doubled in three years.	The peer mentor at Odisee plays the same role as the ASAP advisor — a consistent, proactive human touchpoint at every bi-weekly session. The student never has to self-refer.

University / Country	What They Did and Results	What Odisee Can Take
Missouri State University USA	Identified students with 2.5 GPA or lower at risk. After email outreach largely failed, implemented strategic text messaging to connect at-risk students with advisors. Results: Fall-to-fall retention boosted by one percentage point — 32 students saved from stopping out in year one.	After email failed, one text message saved 32 students. Warm, direct, peer-led outreach through Toledo and WhatsApp will do the same for Odisee Brussels.

8. SWOT Analysis

An honest assessment of the strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats for implementing this protocol at Odisee Brussels.

Strengths	Opportunities
Catches student drift before it becomes dropout Professor workload is one click in Toledo — nothing more Peer mentor is already in the student's life every two weeks No new technology, no new budget, no new sessions 14-day follow-up rule ensures no student is forgotten Warm outreach from a known peer — not a formal letter Traffic light self-correction — many students act before anyone contacts them	Directly aligns with Odisee's policy goal of 75% first-year study efficiency Scalable across all Brussels campus programmes Builds a culture of proactive institutional care Pilot data from Year 1 builds the case for permanent embedding Toledo already exists — the traffic light lives inside it Can be extended to second year with no structural change
Weaknesses	Threats
Requires consistent coordinator follow-through — 14-day rule must be honoured Peer mentor must feel safe to flag concerns without fear of overstepping Quality of outreach depends on mentor training and warmth If Toledo data is not regularly reviewed, signals go unnoticed Programme effectiveness depends on all five roles playing their part	Students may feel surveilled if the protocol is not communicated as care Without coordinator ownership, alerts become a list no one acts on Mentor burnout if Red-level concerns are not escalated promptly Language barriers may delay recognition of distress signals If peer mentor dropout occurs mid-year, the student loses their primary contact

The weaknesses and threats are not reasons to avoid the approach — they are areas where the implementation plan already has responses built in. Professor workload is protected by the one-click Toledo system. Mentor burnout is prevented by the Red-level escalation rule. Student stigma is avoided by framing every outreach as care, not surveillance.

9. SMART Criteria

	Criterion	How This Protocol Meets It
S	Specific	Five defined steps · traffic light framework · standardised Concern Note · referral pathway · 14-day follow-up rule · clear role for every person in the system
M	Measurable	Number of alerts raised per term · proportion with 14-day follow-up · student re-engagement rate · coordinator review records · end-of-year retention data
A	Achievable	No new technology · no new budget · no extra sessions · Concern Note takes 5 minutes · only Amber and Red signals require action · embedded in what already exists
R	Relevant	Directly addresses the study efficiency gap for migrant-background and first-generation students at Odisee Brussels · confirmed in institutional data and partner meetings
T	Time-Bound	Active monitoring Weeks 1–18 · mid-year review Week 10 · end-of-year review Weeks 19–21 · outcomes documented for Year 2

A note to teaching staff and programme coordinators

This protocol is not a surveillance system. It is not a judgment on how you have managed your students before. It is a structured response to a well-documented challenge — students at the Brussels campus drifting away quietly before anyone notices. Your role is one click in Toledo. The peer mentor — someone the student already knows and trusts — does everything after that. You are not responsible for fixing the problem alone. You are part of a system that makes sure no student disappears unnoticed.